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Apple

An **apple** is the round, edible fruit of an apple tree (*Malus* spp.). Fruit trees of the **orchard** or **domestic apple** (***Malus domestica***), the most widely grown in the genus, are cultivated worldwide. The tree originated in Central Asia, where its wild ancestor, *Malus sieversii*, is still found. Apples have been grown for thousands of years in Eurasia before they were introduced to North America by European colonists. Apples have cultural significance in many mythologies (including Norse and Greek) and religions (such as Christianity in Europe).

Apples grown from seeds tend to be very different from those of their parents, and the resultant fruit frequently lacks desired characteristics. For commercial purposes, including botanical evaluation, apple cultivars are propagated by clonal grafting onto rootstocks. Apple trees grown without rootstocks tend to be larger and much slower to fruit after planting. Rootstocks are used to control the speed of growth and the size of the resulting tree, allowing for easier harvesting.

There are more than 7,500 cultivars of apples. Different cultivars are bred for various tastes and uses, including cooking, eating raw, and cider or apple juice production. Trees and fruit are prone to fungal, bacterial, and pest problems, which can be controlled by a number of organic and non-organic means. In 2010, the fruit's genome was sequenced as part of research on disease control and selective breeding in apple production.

Etymology

The word *apple* is derived from Old English *æppel*, meaning "fruit", not specifically the apple.[4] That in turn is descended from the Proto-Germanic noun **aplaz*, descended in turn from Proto-Indo-European **h₂ébōl*.[5] As late as the 17th century, the word also functioned as a generic term for all fruit including nuts; one example is the pineapple, the swollen accessory fruit outside of the cashew nut known as the "cashew apple",[6] another is a 14th-century Middle English expression *appel of paradis*, meaning a banana.[4]

Description

The apple tree is deciduous, generally standing from 2 to 4.5 metres (6 to 15 feet) tall in cultivation and up to 15 m (49 ft) in the wild, though more typically 2 to 10 m (6.5 to 33 ft).[7][2] When cultivated, the size, shape and branch density are determined by rootstock selection and trimming method.[7] Apple trees may naturally have a rounded to erect crown with a dense canopy of leaves.[8] The bark of the trunk is dark gray or gray-brown, but young branches are reddish or dark-brown with a smooth texture.[2][9] Young twigs are covered in fine downy hairs; they become hairless when older.[9]

The buds are egg-shaped and dark red or purple in color; they range in size from 3 to 5mm, but are usually less than 4mm. The bud scales have very hairy edges. When emerging from the buds, the leaves are convolute, meaning that their edges overlap each other.[2] Leaves can be simple ovals (elliptic), medium or wide in width, somewhat egg-shaped with the wider portion toward their base (ovate), or even with sides that are more parallel to each other instead of curved (oblong) with a narrow pointed end.[9][2] The edges have broadly-angled teeth, but do not have lobes. The top surface of the leaves are glabrescent, almost hairless, while the undersides are densely covered in fine hairs.[2] The leaves are attached alternately by short leaf stems 1-to-3.5 cm (½-to-1½ in) long.[8][2]

Apple

'Cripps Pink' cultivar

Flowers of *M. domestica*

Scientific classification

Kingdom:	Plantae
Clade:	Tracheophytes
Clade:	Angiosperms
Clade:	Eudicots
Clade:	Rosids
Order:	Rosales
Family:	Rosaceae
Genus:	*Malus*
Species:	***M. domestica***

Binomial name

Malus domestica
(Suckow) Borkh., 1803[1]

Synonyms[2][3]

- *M. communis* Desf., 1768
- *M. pumila* Mil.